happened."[98] According to Mishra, Operation Parakram's "national goal was to curb terrorism emanating from Pakistan. That national goal . . . was achieved."[99] Thus nuclear weapons' role in limiting the 2001–2002 crisis is mixed. In one instance nuclear weapons had little effect, and in another they did help ameliorate the dispute, though they were not the principal stabilizing factor.

In evaluating nuclear weapons' impact on the 2001–2002 crisis, however, one must not overlook their role in fomenting the standoff. The Parakram confrontation resulted from India's large-scale mobilization and associated coercive diplomacy, which in turn was a reaction to an attack on the Indian parliament and an Indian army installation by Pakistan-backed Kashmiri terrorist groups. The Parliament and Kaluchak attacks were part of a broad pattern of Pakistani low-intensity conflict that was promoted by Pakistan's nuclear weapons capacity. Regardless of any stabilizing effects they may have had later in the 2001–2002 dispute, nuclear weapons played a central role in instigating the crisis in the first place.

Nuclear proliferation thus had a destabilizing effect on South Asia during the period from 1998 to 2002. By encouraging provocative Pakistani behavior and forceful Indian responses, nuclear weapons facilitated the outbreak of the first Indo-Pakistani war in twenty-eight years and the largest-ever South Asian militarized standoff. And although nuclear deterrence did inject a measure of caution into Indian decision-making, it was not critical to stabilizing either dispute. Rather, the Kargil war and the 2001–2002 crisis failed to escalate primarily as the result of India's concern with international opinion, faith in the success of its coercive diplomacy, and conventional military limitations.

CONCLUSION

This chapter examines Indo-Pakistani security relations from the initial stages of South Asia's de facto nuclearization in the late 1980s through the 2001–2002 crisis, when both India and Pakistan possessed overt nuclear capabilities. We seek to explain nuclear weapons' impact on the outbreak, conduct, and resolution of Indo-